Many Kinds of Bacteria Cause an Old Mushroom Disease

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White button mushrooms are a popular food. But for more than 100 years, a disease called **bacterial blotch** has harmed them. It leaves brown or yellow spots, so the mushrooms are harder to sell. They may also **spoil** sooner.

For years, scientists mostly blamed one type of **bacteria**. Now scientists at the University of Florida have found that the disease is much more complicated.

The team collected sick mushrooms from several farms in the southern United States. They used **DNA sequencing**, which reads the **genetic code** of living things, and other lab tests.

They found more than 17 different kinds of harmful **bacteria** linked to the disease. Two well-known kinds were the most common. But the team also found a lot of another group of **bacteria** that had never been linked to the disease before.

Because so many **bacteria** may be involved, treatments aimed at just one kind may not work well. The scientists hope to find better ways to spot and stop the disease.

Word Treasure

bacterial blotch -- A mushroom disease caused by bacteria that leaves brown or yellow spots.

bacteria -- Tiny living things too small to see; some can make plants or people sick.

DNA sequencing -- A lab test that reads the genetic code of living things.

genetic code -- The instructions inside every living thing that tell it how to grow and work.

spoil -- To go bad so it can no longer be eaten.

Background you need

Mushrooms are not plants; they are fungi, and farms often grow them indoors.

Some bacteria can make crops sick, which means farmers have less food to sell.

To stop a disease, scientists first need to know exactly what causes it.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists at the University of Florida
WHAT: They found more than 17 kinds of harmful bacteria linked to a mushroom disease
WHERE: Mushroom farms in the southern United States
WHY: Knowing all the bacteria could help find better ways to stop the disease

Why it matters

Mushrooms are a food many families eat, so stopping this disease helps farmers grow more good mushrooms.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of mushrooms does the disease harm?

- (A) Giant mushrooms
- (B) Red mushrooms
- (C) White button mushrooms
- (D) Glowing mushrooms

2. What color are the spots from bacterial blotch?

- (A) Blue or purple
- (B) Pink
- (C) Green
- (D) Brown or yellow

3. Which university did the study?

- (A) University of Florida
- (B) University of Oregon
- (C) University of Alaska
- (D) University of Texas

4. How many kinds of harmful bacteria did the team find?

- (A) Just one
- (B) More than 17
- (C) Two
- (D) Exactly 100

5. What does DNA sequencing do?

- (A) Counts mushrooms
- (B) Waters plants
- (C) Reads the genetic code of living things
- (D) Takes photos of space

6. Why might treatments not work well?

- (A) It is too cold
- (B) Farmers forgot to use them
- (C) The mushrooms are too big
- (D) So many kinds of bacteria may be involved

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: A 4: B 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):